

Tyson Test

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### Fraternal Benefit Societies and Headstones

For many people, the cost of paying for an honorable burial complete with a headstone can be daunting, especially for those of modest means. The phrase “there is strength in numbers,” is often used in situations where having larger groups of people working for a common goal aids in the achievement of said goal; such situations typically involve problems that are too challenging for an individual or family alone to handle without the assistance of others. Burials exemplify this, and the pooling of financial resources strengthens the numbers. People can join a fraternal benefit society to pool their financial resources. People would benefit from having an overview of how these societies came into being and how they influenced the America of today.

Fraternal benefit societies have a long and storied history. The Roman Empire developed what would now be known as burial/life insurance around 200 BCE. These ancient Romans believed that the dishonorable burial of a Roman, especially one that served in the military, would result in the ghost of the deceased haunting the living. To ensure the proper burial of deceased Roman soldiers, General Gaius Marius established burial clubs for the men under his command; these men could, if they choose, opt into these clubs. Roman burial clubs operated by requiring the men to pay a portion of their salary into a fund that they collectively maintained to defray funeral expenses in the event of falling in the line of duty.

The idea of burial insurance evolved into what is now life insurance in the 18<sup>th</sup> century with the arrival of actuarial science as a discipline of English study. The North American

manifestation of life insurance began around the same time by private companies and non-profit entities. Many faith communities, most notably the Episcopal Church, operated these life insurance policies (The History of Life Insurance).

In addition to faith communities, Americans also developed other burial societies. Railway workers could receive life insurance from the Ancient Order of United Workmen starting in 1868. Jordan Upchurch, a railway mechanic, founded this fraternity. As a fraternity, it was not a union, though it had many labor union members in it. Other fraternities for men and their families would arise later in the century. In 1883 one of these beneficial societies, Modern Woodman of America, was founded by Joseph Cullen Root (Finding Roots in Ancient Rome). Mr. Root chose this name as he was inspired by the demanding work of those who clear wood for western development and settlement. The fraternity itself had nothing to do with woodworking or logging per se. This fraternity is still in existence today and is headquartered in Rock Island Illinois (Modern Woodmen History).

After the founding of Modern Woodmen, Mr. Root founded another fraternity in 1890 named Woodmen Life; he founded the second fraternity as there was infighting within the first fraternity he founded. Before continuing, for the sake of this essay, it cannot be overstated how important it is to not confuse the fraternities with one another. Both fraternities were founded in middle America by the same man around the same time; both fraternities remain headquartered in middle America, Modern Woodmen is based in Rock Island whereas Woodmen Life is based in Omaha Nebraska (Woodmen of the World). Differentiation is being stressed here as the rest of this essay will exclusively look at Woodmen Life, the newer of the two fraternities.

Woodman life boasts a compelling history of helping hundreds of thousands of people, many of whom hail from middle America, achieve financial security and peace of mind. Starting

with its founding in 1890, Woodmen Life offered its members life insurance policies with a clause that provided members with a uniquely designed headstone that identifies the deceased as having belonged to the fraternity. These distinctive headstones adorn older sections of cemeteries throughout the United States; the rapid growth of Woodmen, which reached 750,000 members by 1915, proliferated these headstones (Woodmen Life's Storied History).

Woodmen Life tombstones are iconic for their design, which are sculpted from stone to resemble a tree trunk or stump depending on the person. For an adult, the headstone would be made to be tall like a cut trunk, it could reach heights of between 5-and-6 feet. Whereas for a minor, the stump would be as short as a foot and fashioned with a small stack of 3 or so "baby" tree trunks. Having a cut trunk symbolizes a life cut short, the shorter the trunk the shorter the deceased's life. Other variations of the tree design include tree-stump benches, chairs, and Christian crosses. The use of Christian imagery in these headstones was not limited to the cross; the use of trees harkens back to the book of Genesis, where the use of a tree recalls the forbidden tree of knowledge. As a forever existing source of forbidden knowledge, to the people of the late 19<sup>th</sup> and early 20<sup>th</sup> centuries, the Biblical tree represented both humanity and eternity. As the fraternity is called Woodmen of the World, the use of tree imagery serves another symbolic purpose as a physical manifestation of the use of the fraternity's image (Cecila Wittmayer).

When families of the deceased desired a Woodmen headstone, they had multiple variations on the tree design to choose from, such as the aforementioned "baby" trunks and stump branches, among others. Upon the family's selection, details would be sent to a local Woodmen-approved stonemason for completion. Woodmen-specific symbols such as axes and other equipment related to woodworking may be put on the headstone if desired. Other symbols included a dove with an olive branch in its beak, symbolizing peace for the deceased. On

occasion, individual stone masons would include unique identifying designs on their headstones to signify their work, such as mushrooms. To complete a Woodmen monument, stone masons inscribed information about the deceased's person's life into the stone along with the Latin phrase *Dum Tacet Clamet*, which translates to "though silent he speaks." "Here rests a Woodmen of the World," was another phrase that would on occasion be inscribed in the headstone in addition to or instead of the Latin phrase (Story of the Tree Stump Tombstones).

Here in Vermillion, at Bluff View Cemetery, you can find an example of a Woodman headstone. It is to be found in one of the older sections of Bluff View, which is consistent with Woodman headstones in other American Cemeteries. The one to be found in Bluff View is one of the taller models that proudly stands high above the other headstones in the cemetery; the headstone features ornate details of flowers and leaves as if from a vine snaking up along a tree trunk. The information on the headstone is found on a design element that is made to look like a scroll that hangs from the trunk with the aid of a stone-carved rope. On this scroll, it can be observed that it is the final resting place of Ghass Overhulse. He died on the first of January of 1894 when he was 19 years, 8 months, and 2 days old; the date of birth is not mentioned, only the age of the deceased. The headstone also provides us with information about who erected it, that being G.B. and E.R. Overhulse. The commonality of the last names implies that the stonemasons for the headstone were related to the young man buried there. Quite possibly, a stonemason father sculpted this headstone for his son; that being said, the familial connection itself is not stated on the headstone, so it cannot be known for sure based on the available information. This headstone also features a large blank area on the scroll that would easily have accommodated burial information from a couple more deceased individuals. That this space was

never utilized implies that the family that sculpted the stone left the area before needing to use it for its intended purpose.

To sum up, the cost of ensuring a respectful burial for departed loved ones has long been a challenge for many families. To cope with these challenges, many American families have been members of fraternal benefit societies. These non-profits help their members pool their financial resources to support members. They can also influence the style of headstones that family members use for their loved ones if they offer headstones. This is most clearly demonstrated with Woodmen Life's tree trunk headstones which can be found throughout the United States and in Vermillion's Bluff View Cemetery.

## Works Cited Page

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